Forum:	UN Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO)
Issue:	Balancing globalisation-driven economic development and the preservation of cultural heritage
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Personal Introduction

Dear delegates,

It is an honour to welcome you all to the 1st MOMUN conference! My name is Vasilis Lialios; I am an 11th-grade student at the Erasmeios Greek-German School and I am going to serve as one of the Chairs in the UNESCO Committee.

Firstly, I would like to congratulate you on joining the MUN community. Model UN fosters critical thinking and tackling problems through innovation, paving the way for the next generation of diplomats and policymakers. Even more so, however, MUN is a challenge. For this reason, regardless of your personal career or study path (and whether you want to engage in something affiliated with or similar to MUN), there is always something to gain from each conference. I urge you to take advantage of this opportunity, have fruitful discussions, form bonds with other delegates and enjoy your time at MOMUN!

The following study guide contains information on the topic of balancing globalisation-driven economic development and the preservation of cultural heritage. Its aim is to help you gain a basic grasp of the topic. Keep in mind, however, that you are meant to conduct your own individual research in order to acquire the necessary depth of knowledge to properly represent your country. Should you have any enquiries about the rules of procedure, your stance as a delegation, or the topic in general, feel free to contact me at mun.vlialios@gmail.com.

Looking forward to meeting you all!

Best regards,

Vasilis

Introduction

In recent decades, globalisation has grown in significance when it comes to supporting financial and economic development although its pace has varied. At this time, it is important to recognise the need to pay attention to culture and traditions and how we can cooperate in order to assist Member States in their efforts to preserve such a paramount part of their identity. Globalisation and its effects on economic development can pose great dangers to the maintenance and preservation of local cultural

heritage, especially in Member States that rely on it for their economies on a large scale, potentially hindering their ability to provide effective education to their people and weakening their position in the global market.

Key Terms and Definitions

Globalisation[1]

Integration of the world's economies, politics, and cultures. The modern phase of the phenomenon is widely considered to have begun in the 19th century following the advent of the Industrial Revolution, but some scholars date it more specifically to about 1870, when exports became a much more significant share of some countries' gross domestic product (GDP). Its expansion is largely attributable to the development of new technologies—particularly in the fields of communication and transportation—and to the adoption of liberal trade policies by countries around the world.

Cultural heritage[2]

UNESCO describes World Heritage as places of outstanding universal value and defines culture as a set of distinctive spiritual, material, intellectual, and emotional features of a society or a social group. These features can be expressed as art, literature, lifestyles, ways of living together, traditions and beliefs. World Heritage sites are designated under the Convention Concerning the Protection of the World Cultural and Natural Heritage, which UNESCO adopted in 1972 and came into force on 17 December 1975, three months after the twentieth instrument of ratification, acceptance or accession was deposited. This convention laid out our current framework for the preservation and stewardship of major cultural heritage sites across the globe. It also provides a possible infrastructure through which to consider what "cultural heritage" is in the first place.

Mass Tourism[3]

Large crowds of tourists visiting the same destination, often creating economic benefits, but also causing overcrowding, environmental damage and pressure on cultural heritage sites.

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[1] Volle, A. (2024, February 16). Globalization. *In Encyclopaedia Britannica.* https://www.britannica.com/money/globalization

[2] What is cultural heritage? (n.d.). Whose Culture? *Harvard University.* https://whoseculture.hsites.harvard.edu/what-world-heritage

[3] Tourism Notes. (2023, August 23). Mass tourism: History, types, advantages & disadvantages, destinations and its impacts. https://tourismnotes.com/mass-tourism/

Sustainable Development Goal 11 Target 11.4[4]

Under Sustainable Development Goal 11 (SDG 11), Target 11.4 calls for efforts to protect and safeguard the world's cultural and natural heritage. SDG Indicator 11.4.1 tracks per capita expenditure on heritage preservation from public and private sources across all government levels. The UNESCO Institute for Statistics (UIS) leads this effort, creating a standardised methodology and robust database. Since 2020, UIS has collected annual data, improving coverage and quality through capacity-building and methodological guidance. This supports countries in achieving sustainable, resilient societies aligned with the 2030 Agenda.

List of World Heritage in Danger[5]

As of 28 October 2026, the list contains 58 properties which the World Heritage Committee has decided to include on the List of World Heritage in Danger in accordance with Article 11(4)[6] of the *Convention*. The List of World Heritage in Danger is designed to inform the international community of conditions which threaten the very characteristics for which a property was inscribed on the World Heritage List, and to encourage corrective action.

Background Information



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(Fig. 1) A chart of the value of global trade as a percentage of gross domestic product (GDP) from 1970 to 2024, showing changes in globalisation and its role in the global economy.

[4] UNESCO Institute for Statistics. (n.d.). SDG 11.4.1 indicators. https://www.uis.unesco.org/en/methods-and-tools/sdg114-indicators

[5] UNESCO World Heritage Centre. (n.d.-d). List of World Heritage in Danger. *Retrieved October 28*, 2026, from https://whc.unesco.org/en/danger-list/

[6] UNESCO. (1972). Convention concerning the protection of the world cultural and natural h*eritage (Art. 11)*. https://whc.unesco.org/en/conventiontext/#Article11.4

[7] Richter, F. (n.d.). Has globalization passed its peak? [*Infographic]*. Statista. https://www.statista.com/chart/21821/global-trade-volume-as-a-percentage-of-gdp/

Historical Development of the Issue

Globalisation has connected economies through trade, investment, migration and the exchange of ideas. Modern economic integration expanded during the nineteenth century as transport and communications improved, and developed further after the Second World War through greater international cooperation and lower trade barriers. More recently, digital networks have enabled services and cultural products to reach audiences across borders. These changes can create employment and increase access to markets, but their benefits are not distributed equally. For cultural heritage, the central issue is how economic change affects the places, practices and communities through which people maintain their identities.[8]

International heritage protection developed partly in response to the limits of national resources and the pressures created by changing social and economic conditions. The 1972 World Heritage Convention established a framework for cooperation around cultural and natural heritage of outstanding universal value. However, responsibility for protection remains primarily with the State concerned. World Heritage status does not transfer ownership or ordinary planning powers to UNESCO, and not all culturally important places are inscribed on the World Heritage List. Delegates should therefore distinguish international recognition from the national laws and institutions that protect heritage in everyday practice.[9]

Economic Opportunities and Cultural Value

Culture can contribute to economic development through tourism, creative work and the sale of cultural goods and services. International markets may allow artists, publishers and other cultural producers to reach audiences that would otherwise be inaccessible. At the same time, the value of their work cannot be measured only by sales. The 2005 UNESCO Convention recognises that cultural goods and services carry identities, values and meanings as well as having an economic role. This gives governments a reason to consider cultural diversity when developing economic policy, while respecting human rights and their other international obligations.[10]

Heritage tourism can create demand for guides, accommodation, local food, traditional crafts and conservation skills. Whether these activities strengthen a community depends on who owns the businesses, who can obtain work and how income is used. A destination may receive many visitors without generating sufficient resources for maintaining its heritage. Local participation in tourism planning and opportunities for local enterprises can help connect tourism income to conservation and community needs. The relevant measure of success is therefore broader than visitor numbers: it also

8 Jakubik and Van Heuvelen (2024), "Back to basics: Globalization today".

9 UNESCO (1972), World Heritage Convention, Arts. 1–7 and 11.

10 UNESCO (2005), Convention on the Protection and Promotion of the Diversity of Cultural Expressions, preamble and Arts. 1–2, 5–6.

concerns the quality of employment, the distribution of benefits and the resources available for long-term protection.[11]

Tourism Pressure and the Use of Heritage Sites

Tourism can also place pressure on the heritage that attracts visitors. The concentration of people in a small area may damage fragile surfaces, obstruct access and create waste or traffic problems. These effects depend on the site's condition, the timing and behaviour of visits, and the capacity of those responsible for its management. A single visitor limit is therefore not a complete management strategy. Timed entry, appropriate routes, clear information and the monitoring of sensitive areas can help authorities respond to particular risks. Measures should be reviewed against evidence of their effects on both conservation and the visitor experience.[12]

Urban Development and Historic Communities

Economic growth creates demand for housing, transport and commercial space. In historic urban areas, these needs may conflict with the protection of buildings, archaeological remains and the wider setting of heritage sites. The surroundings of a monument can be important to its significance, even when construction does not physically touch the monument itself. UNESCO's Historic Urban Landscape approach encourages cities to consider buildings, landscapes, social practices and economic activity together. This helps explain why heritage planning cannot be limited to restoring individual landmarks while ignoring changes in the neighbourhood around them.[13]

Historic districts are also places where people live and work. Development decisions need to account for residents' access to housing, public services and shared spaces. If an area becomes primarily a visitor destination, the activities that sustain its character may become harder to maintain. Conversely, refusing all change may leave buildings unused and fail to meet community needs. The planning challenge is to identify which features and relationships carry cultural significance, then assess how proposed changes could affect them. Public consultation matters because expert assessments and residents' experiences can reveal different aspects of a place's value.

Living Heritage and Community Participation

Cultural heritage also includes living practices, knowledge and skills, such as oral traditions, festivals and craftsmanship. Their survival depends on people continuing to practise and pass them on. Commercial demand may provide an income for practitioners, but it can also encourage performances or products to be adapted mainly to visitors' expectations. UNESCO's ethical principles

11 UNESCO World Heritage Centre (n.d.-c), How to guides for managing tourism, Guides 4, 7 and 9.

12 UNESCO World Heritage Centre (n.d.-a), Guide 8: Managing visitor behaviour.

13 UNESCO (2011), Recommendation on the Historic Urban Landscape, especially paras. 8–13 and 22–26.

identify misrepresentation, removal from cultural context and commodification as potential threats. They also recognise that living heritage changes over time. Safeguarding should therefore support communities in deciding how their practices develop, rather than imposing an externally defined, permanently fixed version of tradition.[14]

Community involvement must extend beyond being informed after decisions have been made. UNESCO's ethical principles call for transparent collaboration and free, prior, sustained and informed consent in interactions with heritage communities. They also recognise communities' interests in the benefits arising from the use of their heritage and the need to respect customary restrictions on access. For delegates, this raises practical questions about representation: who speaks for a community, how younger practitioners participate, and how disagreements are handled. Public visibility or commercial promotion should not automatically override the wishes of the people who maintain a tradition.

Planning and Institutional Barriers

A major difficulty is the separation of economic planning from heritage management. A project may be assessed mainly for employment or transport benefits before its cultural effects have been examined. UNESCO and its advisory bodies recommend impact assessments early enough to influence the choice of location, design and alternatives. An assessment should examine how a proposal affects the specific qualities that give a heritage place its significance, including effects beyond the site boundary. If it begins only after approval or construction, opportunities to avoid damage may already have been lost.[15]

Effective implementation also requires clear responsibilities. Planning authorities, tourism bodies, heritage specialists and local communities may approach the same project with different priorities. A management process needs to establish who provides information, who makes the decision, who pays for mitigation and who monitors the result. These are practical governance questions for delegates to consider when comparing policy options. A commitment to protect heritage is more credible when it is connected to an enforceable planning decision, a funded management task and a way to respond if damage occurs.

Machu Picchu and the Management of Tourism

The Historic Sanctuary of Machu Picchu illustrates the connection between tourism income and conservation pressure. UNESCO identifies tourism as both a source of economic benefits and a cause of cultural and ecological impacts. Its account of management requirements emphasises regulating

14 UNESCO (2015), Ethical principles for safeguarding intangible cultural heritage, principles 1, 4–5 and 7–12.

15 UNESCO World Heritage Centre (2022), Guidance and toolkit for impact assessments in a World Heritage context.

access, improving understanding of visitor impacts and reinvesting an appropriate share of tourism revenue in planning and management. It also identifies transport, infrastructure and coordination between different levels of government as continuing concerns. The example shows why protecting an archaeological site requires decisions about the wider destination, including the services and routes through which visitors reach it.[16]

Liverpool and the Consequences of Incompatible Development

Liverpool's Maritime Mercantile City provides a contrasting example involving urban redevelopment. The property was inscribed on the World Heritage List in 2004 and placed on the List of World Heritage in Danger in 2012. In 2021, the World Heritage Committee deleted it from the World Heritage List because it considered that developments had caused an irreversible loss of the attributes conveying its outstanding universal value. The decision concerned development within the property and its buffer zone. It illustrates that international recognition cannot by itself prevent damaging change, and that resolving conflicts before construction is more effective than relying on recognition after important features have been lost.[17]

Financing and Measuring Progress

Conservation requires continuing expenditure, not only funding for a major restoration or a tourism campaign. Authorities need to account for maintenance, staff, research and monitoring when considering the affordability of protection. SDG Indicator 11.4.1 measures expenditure per person on cultural and natural heritage, including public and private funding. This provides a basis for examining investment, but expenditure alone does not establish that a site is well conserved or that a living practice remains viable. Delegates should consider financial information alongside the condition of heritage, participation by communities and the ability to sustain protection over time.[18]

The balance between development and preservation will differ between countries and communities. A proposal should therefore make its assumptions clear: which heritage is affected, which economic need it addresses, whose interests are represented and how benefits and costs will be shared. These questions connect the background of the issue to the negotiations that follow. They allow delegates to assess whether a measure would help communities meet present needs while retaining the cultural resources and opportunities available to future generations.

Timeline of Events

16 UNESCO World Heritage Centre (n.d.-b), Historic Sanctuary of Machu Picchu, "Protection and management requirements".

17 UNESCO (2021), World Heritage Committee deletes Liverpool – Maritime Mercantile City from UNESCO's World Heritage List.

18 UNESCO Institute for Statistics (n.d.), SDG 11.4.1 indicators.

Date	Description of Event
19th century–1914	"Globalisation 1.0": textiles and industrial goods become leading exports.
16 November 1945	UNESCO's Constitution is adopted.
1945–1989	"Globalisation 2.0": factory-produced goods drive expanding trade.
1972	The United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO) adopts the World Heritage Convention: legal basis of the World Heritage List
1989–2008	"Globalisation 3.0": expansion of global supply chains.
2015	UN Sustainable Development Goals established
2010s onwards	"Globalisation 4.0": digital goods and services gain importance in trade. Focus increasingly includes the provision of services.

Major Actors Involved

United States of America (USA)

The USA has been a core factor when it comes to global economic growth and globalisation since the mid-19th century. For this reason, it has contributed to problems associated with globalisation and has itself faced tensions between economic growth and cultural preservation. During its history, territorial expansion and assimilation policies have damaged and restricted Indigenous peoples' cultures and identities.

People's Republic of China (PRC)

As a nation with a rich cultural history, as well as an important role in Globalisation 4.0, China faces the need to balance economic advancements and cultural identity.

Peru

For Peru, having Machu Picchu is economically important through tourism, but authorities have had to manage visitor numbers, transport routes, and nearby development to reduce damage to the landscape and archaeological remains.

UNESCO

As well as being the topic's forum, the UN Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization has taken steps towards maintaining the balance between economy and tradition since its founding in 1945.

International Council on Monuments and Sites (ICOMOS)

Its purpose is to evaluate cultural sites and advise on conservation methods. It promotes heritage-impact assessments before major construction, infrastructure, or tourism projects.

UN Documents and International Agreements

Resolution 2347 (2017) Security Council

This resolution affirms that UN peacekeeping operations, when specifically mandated by the Security Council and in accordance with their rules of engagement, may assist relevant authorities, upon their request, in the protection of cultural heritage from destruction, illicit excavation, looting and smuggling in the context of armed conflicts, in collaboration with UNESCO, and affirms that such operations should exercise due regard when in the vicinity of cultural and historical sites. As for its success, it strengthened recognition of the importance of protecting cultural heritage and its role in international peace and security. That said, continuing conflicts and heritage destruction illustrate challenges to its implementation.

Resolution 58/4 (2025) Human Rights Council

This resolution promotes enhanced international cooperation in preventing and combating the organised looting, smuggling and theft of and illicit trafficking in cultural objects and in restoring stolen, looted or trafficked cultural property to its country of origin. Taking into account its recency, its long-term success and achievements remain to be assessed and it will depend on how Member States implement the proposed commitments.

Convention for the Safeguarding of the Intangible Cultural Heritage (2003) UNESCO

The 2003 UNESCO Convention protects living cultural traditions by requiring States Parties to identify, preserve, and promote intangible heritage through national action and international cooperation, helping these traditions continue to be passed on to future generations. UNESCO's 2021 evaluation deemed that it was one of the most successful UNESCO cultural conventions, particularly because it increased recognition of the importance of living/intangible heritage.

Previous Attempts to Solve the Issue

UNESCO 1972 Convention

In 1972, the United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO) adopted the World Heritage Convention and provided for the establishment of the World Heritage List. The

Convention requires States Parties to identify, protect, conserve, and pass on cultural and natural heritage of "Outstanding Universal Value" while also creating international assistance mechanisms for heritage sites under threat. As for its impact, the Convention provides a global framework for heritage protection and raising international awareness. However, its effectiveness ultimately depends on national governments providing adequate enforcement, funding, and long-term conservation efforts.

UN Sustainable Development Goal 11.4

Calls on countries to strengthen efforts to protect and safeguard the world's cultural and natural heritage as part of making cities more inclusive, safe, resilient, and sustainable. Target 11.4 has elevated heritage protection as a global development priority and established a shared international target. However, progress remains uneven, and the 2030 Agenda's deadline has not yet been reached.

UNESCO World Heritage and Sustainable Tourism Programme

Promotes tourism policies that protect cultural and natural heritage, reduce the negative impacts of overcrowding and mass tourism, and ensure that tourism revenue benefits local communities. The programme provides international guidance and promotes awareness of sustainable tourism practices. However, its ability to reduce the real-world impacts of tourism on heritage sites varies, as implementation largely depends on national and local authorities.

International Council on Monuments and Sites (ICOMOS) International Charter for Cultural Heritage Tourism, 2022

In 2022, ICOMOS adopted the International Charter for Cultural Heritage Tourism, calling for more sustainability in relation to tourism, through cooperation with Indigenous communities for the management of heritage sites and moving further away from past tourism models focusing solely on economic development. It served as an attempt to reach a balance between revenue and economic growth and the maintenance of cultural heritage and local identity. Regarding its effectiveness, it mainly comes down to governments, tourism organisations and businesses, and local communities implementing the principles proposed.

Possible Solutions

Raising awareness of the importance of sustainable tourism

The creation of a council focused on raising awareness of the benefits of sustainable tourism for local economies, as well as the prevention of mass tourism, highlighting the detrimental effects it has on cultural heritage and promoting the implementation of previous initiatives on the matter.

Strengthening the List of World Heritage in Danger

Ensuring timely updates to the List of World Heritage in Danger after events deemed significant, whether beneficial or harmful, would help identify sites facing serious threats, such as armed conflict, uncontrolled development, natural disasters, or poor management. This would attract greater

attention from other Member States, increase access to technical support, and encourage additional conservation funding.

Improving Heritage Site Security

Heritage sites should receive better security and protection at all times. This could be achieved through a digital monitoring system or with increased local supervision and UN support within applicable mandates.

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